Last chance

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52604002.

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by Madgirlmuahaha

Summary

There was an expiration date on the affair and they both knew it. He didn't realize it would come so soon, though.

Notes

This is partly inspired by an angsty 100-word drabble I did months ago, and partly inspired by a meme Alex posted to discord. Thank you for the inspiration!

Consider this the extended cut of that angsty drabble.

See the end of the work for more notes

It was never supposed to go this far. The sex had been an experiment—something that she had propositioned on a quiet night together in the sanctum, when the tension between them was too distracting to focus on their work. She was so warm and inviting, and one curious kiss had quickly spiraled into something so much more.

He couldn't afford a relationship. He had to maintain his fierce persona of a warlord for his Horde, showing any sign of vulnerability was an opportunity for his enemy to strike. Entrapta understood. Discretion was paramount. Everything that occurred in his bedchambers was kept as a secret between them.

Of course there were rumors, but Entrapta was a competent enough accomplice not to leave behind any concrete evidence, so the rumors remained as idle, unsubstantiated gossip. Her cunning and craftiness proved very useful in maintaining discretion and finding covert ways for their affair to continue.

Hordak had never had an affair partner before, but she was a perfect match for him. Sneaky enough to keep things secret, bold enough to challenge him in new and exciting ways, bright enough to build upon his ideas. She was a fascinating creature, full of compassion and curiosity and enthusiasm.

As their portal project neared completion, a new feeling blossomed in his heart: dread and grief for the inevitable day when he would wake up without her at his side.

But he *had* to do it. He needed to go home, to return to his master and present Lord Prime with a conquered Etheria. His soul ached for purpose, and total domination was the only way to win his master's favor. He would earn the good graces of Lord Prime again, he would prove himself as a worthy servant. He must.

Ultimately, keeping Entrapta nearby was more of a boon than a distraction. That was what he told himself, anyway, to justify the

affair. Because without justification, all that remained was mere sentimentality, and relying on that would lead to his destruction.

This woman was going to be the death of him.

Entrapta had never before questioned his leadership, though she had challenged him in matters of science and intercourse plenty of times. Despite the status that her title implied, she'd never really shown any interest in taking a leadership position within the Horde's ranks beyond the station of lead engineer. Heck, she seemed to actively shirk any leadership responsibilities in her own domain whenever they popped up.

Yet, she had confronted him about his treatment of Catra, pointing out how reckless it had been to appoint her in Shadow Weaver's position when she clearly had a conflict of interest and lack of experience. If he hadn't been so blinded by rage at Shadow Weaver's misconduct, perhaps he wouldn't have allowed her least favorite ward to take charge of her imprisonment. Her escape had been a completely avoidable disaster, had he thought through things more clearly and appointed a more competent soldier instead.

Catra was young and dumb: this much was obvious. She was impulsive and reckless, but also (in Entrapta's opinion, at least) a valuable tool for field missions.

Entrapta's argument for mercy had been compelling—even more so after another sensuous night spent in each other's company. Despite the risk Catra posed as an emotionally volatile and easily manipulated little monster, he decided to grant her one last chance to prove herself in the Crimson Waste. If anybody could summon the stubbornness to survive in that desolate wasteland, it would be Catra.

Entrapta had a way of worming into his brain and making him agree with her, like she was magic or something. Maybe she truly was magic, but instead of being channeled through an elemental runestone, her magic was channeled directly to his heart and mind. That would explain why he was helpless to stop her from influencing him.

Maybe he shouldn't try to resist her influence. Maybe she deserved a more prominent leadership position in the Horde, if she wanted it.

The portal was waiting for the final piece. If Catra returned, it would all be over.

It should have been the most joyous day of Hordak's life. Almost thirty years spent trapped on this desolate planet, ostracized from Lord Prime and his light. So many years spent staring up at a starless sky, all leading up to this moment. He could finally go home.

Why did he feel such a crushing sense of dread?

He looked to Entrapta, and his heart leapt into his throat. Very soon now, it would be time to say goodbye to her forever. Once he walked through the portal and entered Prime's embrace, his life would be solely devoted to His service. He would never be able to see her again without acting as a servant of Prime. More than likely, he would have to renounce his name and memories to be accepted back into the fold.

Both of them, from the beginning, had known that there was an expiration date on the affair. Returning home had always been his plan, and she was completely accepting of this inevitability. It didn't matter to her, she'd insisted. She was just happy to finally find someone who understood her, even if their time together was limited.

A bitter tang settled in his mouth as he was forced to confront the impermanence of their relationship. Each day that they waited for Catra to return could be the last day he woke up to see Entrapta in his bed. Every smile she gave him could be the last memory he had of her, every kiss or hug or subtle stroke of her hair could be the last touch shared between them. He wanted to preserve every last one of these final memories to savor them when he could no longer feel her soft body with his hands, but also he felt the urge to destroy everything that reminded him of her. How could his life ever go back to normal without her, now that he had known what it was like to live with her at his side?

It was blasphemy, he knew. The most grievous of offenses in the galactic Horde was to allow one's ego and desires to supersede the will of Lord Prime.

He wanted so badly to keep her, but it could never be, no matter how tempting it was to go public with their relationship and proudly declare her his Lady.

Hordak sat on his throne after completing a debriefing with his force captains, deep in contemplation. Catra had recovered something in the Crimson Waste and contacted the other captains, she was apparently en route right now. If she had the missing piece to the portal, this really was the last time for everything.

This was his last chance to tell Entrapta.

Entrapta bounded in from the vents, either unaware or unbothered about the end of their shared world. She had a wide smile, like usual, and whatever composure Hordak had managed to maintain this far was completely shattered. He could not fathom never seeing this beautiful smile again.

"Entrapta, I'm going to request something reckless and impulsive, and I need you to be the voice of reason and tell me no."

She swayed back on her pigtails with a devious grin. "But being an accomplice is more fun than being the voice of reason! C'mon, I want to help! We're lab partners, Hordak. What are you up to?"

Hordak growled out in frustration, anxiously digging his claws into the armrests of his throne. By the light of Prime, this woman was *impossible!* So eager to stir up trouble and enable his worst impulses, to be his partner in science and crime. Stars, how he loved her.

His whole body became feverish as he raised his gaze to look at her again. He tried to summon enough pomp to mask the desperation in his soul, but he knew that Entrapta would see through it. She understood him almost better than he understood himself, even though she'd told him multiple times that she generally struggled to intuit other people's thoughts and feelings. He hoped that she wouldn't see the turbulent emotions roiling deep within him, but it was useless to hide from Entrapta. She was a curious, brilliant woman who had a way of finding things out, anyway.

"I need you to say no to me," Hordak pleaded, in a choked voice that was far more pathetic than he'd intended.

Entrapta's brow furrowed. "Well… okay, then. If that's what you need from me. What do you need me to say no to?"

His heart ached with relief and dread in anticipation for something that he wanted desperately, but could not have. He must not have it. But the question of "what if?" burned in the deepest pits of his heart, too painful and intense to ignore. He had to say it before leaving her behind, and with Entrapta's rejection already secured, he was safe in the knowledge that it would never happen.

"I want to marry you."

He could not bring himself to meet her gaze, only to bury his head in his hands and wait with held breath for the inevitable rejection. All she had to do was say "no," then he could finally bury these feelings for good, and be free to return home. It was a completely irrational impulse on his part, there was no way that their lives could be permanently intertwined in marriage without suffering grievous consequences. Especially for Entrapta—her reputation and standing with her people would be completely destroyed if she shackled herself to the warlord leader of the Horde.

Nothing more than a small gasp and a long silence answered him.

When he finally looked up again in confusion, Entrapta was perched on his armrest, fiddling with her hair. She hummed in contemplation. "Do you really mean it?"

Her words bounced right off Hordak's thick skull. He stared blankly at her, confused at the noticeable lack of her promised rejection. "What?"

"That marriage is something you want for us?"

His face flushed, and his ears tilted down. "I can't—Entrapta, I am sorry to drag you into my emotional quandary, but I *need* you to be the reasonable one here. I need you to say no. We can't get married."

"Can't?" She frowned. "Well, technically speaking we *could.* Heck, I could make a few calls to Dryl and have all the paperwork ready before dinner."

"Entrapta!" At this point, his face was burning. "I need to return home! Catra is due to return any minute now with what is supposed to be the key to the portal, and I cannot marry you if I must leave you behind!"

Entrapta snapped her mouth shut, and he regretted everything.

She was quiet for a long, long time. With every second that ticked by, Hordak expected the doors to fly open with Catra wielding the

final key to the portal.

It didn't happen.

Entrapta crossed her arms, rubbing them together in a self-soothing motion. "If you stayed, would you be happy here?"

If he could hold on to all of his memories with her instead of sacrificing them on the altar of service to his Lord? If he could touch and taste her again, instead of leaving her behind forever? If he could wake up with her in bed every morning and take in her beautiful smile, instead of trying in vain to win over the affection of a creator who had disowned and exiled him?

"Of course I would be happy," Hordak croaked out, "Happiness is irrelevant. It is not my duty to pursue happiness."

She kissed him, and he was drowning in her presence, helpless to argue any further.

"I can't tell you what to prioritize in your life," Entrapta said as she briefly came up for air. "But I think you should be allowed to pursue whatever makes you happy. You should be allowed to want things. And I don't think anybody has the authority to dictate what you are and aren't allowed to want—not the princess alliance, not the Dryl council, and certainly not Horde Prime."

He kissed her back, dragging her into his lap until she was completely entangled with him. All he wanted anymore was to feel her sweet embrace surrounding him. He wanted this moment to never end.

"I want you," he finally said between desperate kisses. "I love you."

Tears glistened in her eyes as her hair coiled around him affectionately. "I love you, too."

"I'll stay for you."

Her quiet tears turned to full-blown sobs, and Hordak thought he was going to be strangled with how tightly she clung to him. "I always wanted you to stay, but I was too afraid to ask," she spoke in a muffled voice against his chest.

Catra returned with a data chip from a broken down First One's ship in the middle of the wastelands. It was a fascinating find that Entrapta was eager to analyze, but lacked the sufficient capabilities to make the portal function. Despite this, Catra was allowed back into the Horde's ranks at a lower position, on probation.

In choosing to pursue happiness and forge a life with Entrapta, Lord Hordak decided to dismantle the portal project and rerouted the power source to supply the new and improved robotics laboratory. Without the portal taking up so much of his time and attention, he could now afford to dedicate himself to advancing the Horde's technology, and spending more quality time with his partner outside of the lab.

Entrapta assembled all of the correct paperwork. They were married two days later in a ceremony that lasted for exactly six minutes and eighteen seconds, with a handful of top Force Captains present as witnesses (Scorpia included). Absolutely nobody in the Horde was surprised, except for the few people who thought they were already married.

End Notes

Now I just need to update FoA and finish my other WIP's, lol. I feel like I've been creatively constipated for almost two months and it's all just coming out now. Something about the New Year inspires me.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!